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ELIJAH WATSON

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Summary

I am an anthropologist-demographer studying how historical and contemporary societal shocks shape local population health in social, economic, and evolutionary context.

Research Areas: developmental origins of health and disease; natural experiments; social epigenomics and genomics; longitudinal (birth) cohorts

Professional Appointments

2026- **NIH T32 Postdoctoral Research Fellow**, University of Chicago
NIA Specialized Training Program in the Demography and Economics of Aging
Department of Sociology and Center for Health and the Social Sciences

Education

PhD Biological Anthropology, Northwestern University 2026
Certificates: Society, Biology, and Health
Management for PhDs, Northwestern Kellogg School of Management

MPH Epidemiology, Northwestern University, Feinberg School of Medicine 2026

MA Anthropology, Northwestern University 2023

BA Anthropology, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill 2019
Minor: Medicine, Literature, and Culture
Study Abroad: Honors Carolina Semester in Cape Town, South Africa (2017)

Awards

Grants

- **NIH/NIA (F31) Ruth L. Kirschstein Predoctoral Individual National Research Service Award |** ($88,110) *2024-2026*
  - In support of my dissertation research on early life exposures, educational attainment, and epigenetic age acceleration in adulthood
  - (NIH/NIA: F31AG084273**)**
- **National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellow (GRFP) |** $138,000 *2020*
- **UNC Frances L. Phillips Travel Scholarship**: Awarded to support travel to the Galapagos Islands and South Africa for fieldwork and experiential learning to inform future research on food and water insecurity | ($9,500) *2019*
- **UNC Undergraduate Research Consultant Team Grant |** ($10,000) *2019*
  - Pilot study on food and water security on Isabela Island, Galápagos *(collaboration with Universidad San Francisco de Quito & UNC Galápagos Science Center)*
- **UNC Gillian T. Cell Senior Thesis Research Grant** *2018*

Scholarships and Awards

- **E.E. Hunt, Jr. Award**, Human Biology Association, awarded for an outstanding graduate student oral presentation *2024*
- **Tuition Scholarship,** Short course on causal inference, Department of Epidemiology, Harvard T. H. Chan School of Public Health *2022*
- **Travel Award,** Interdisciplinary Association of Population Health Scientists *2022*
- **Honigmann Undergraduate Thesis Award**, UNC Dept. of Anthropology *2019*
- **Travel Award**, Harvard School of Public Health, Center for Communicable Disease Dynamics, Conference to Increase Diversity in Mathematical Modeling & Public Health *2019*

Publications

Peer-reviewed Manuscripts

- **Elijah Watson**, Delaney Glass, and Lucia Petito. (2025). Toward New Directions in Human Biology: A Roadmap for Anthropological Causal Inference with Observational Data. *American Journal of Human Biology.* (link)
- Chihua Li, Rebecca Stebbins, Grace Noppert, Constanza Carney, Chunyu Liu, Ashley Sapp, **Elijah Watson**, and Allison Aiello. (2024). Peripheral Immune Function and Alzheimer's Disease: A Living Systematic Review and Critical Appraisal. *Molecular Psychiatry.* (link)
- Margaret Butler, Britney Smart, **Elijah Watson**, Shreya Narla, and Lauren Keenan-Devlin. (2023). Breastfeeding durations differ at the intersection of race/ethnicity and educational attainment in a nationally representative sample from the US. *Journal of Human Lactation.* (link)
- Melissa Manus, **Elijah Watson**., Sahana Kuthyar, Delia Carba, Nikola Belarmino, Thomas McDade, Christopher Kuzawa, and Katherine Amato. (2023). Prenatal household size and composition are associated with infant fecal bacterial diversity in Cebu, Philippines. *American Journal of Biological Anthropology.* (link)
- Amanda Thompson, Khristopher Nicholas, **Elijah Watson**, Enrique Terán, and Margaret Bentley. (2019). Water, food, and the dual burden of disease in Galápagos, Ecuador. *American Journal of Human Biology.* (link)

Manuscripts under Review

- Thomas W. McDade, Sofia Carrera, Calen P. Ryan, **Elijah Watson**, Linda S. Adair, Nanette R. Lee, Delia B. Carba, Julie L. MacIsaac, Kristy Dever, Michael S. Kobor, Christopher W. Kuzawa. "Chronic inflammation and multiple dimensions of aging among women in the Philippines." Revised and resubmitted at *Journals of Gerontology: Biological Sciences.*
- Delaney J. Glass, Jeffrey G. Snodgrass, Choeeta Chakrabarti, Kateryna Maltseva, Katya Xinyi Zhao, **Elijah Watson**, François Dengah, and Seth Sagstetter "Counterfactual Logic Improves Ethnographic Explanation: Bridging Anthropological and Interdisciplinary Perspectives on Causality." Submitted to *Journal of Mixed Methods Research.*

Conference Presentations and Invited Talks

Recent Talks

- **EJ Watson**, Thomas McDade, Lucia Petito, Michael Kobor, Calen Ryan, Nanette Lee, Linda Adair, and Christopher Kuzawa. "The Fetal Origins of Biological Aging: Evidence from the 1983 Philippine Economic Crisis"
    - Berkeley Formal Demography Workshop, 2025
    - Montgomery Lecture Series, Center for Medical Humanities and Bioethics, Northwestern University Feinberg School of Medicine, January 2026
    - UCLA/USC Workshop on Determinants of Adult Mortality, Morbidity, and Healthy Aging in LMICs, March 2026
    - Colloquium Talk, Department of Data and Decision Sciences, Emory University, April 2026
    - Population Association of America, May 2026
    - The Advances in Social Genomics Conference, University of Wisconsin-Madison, May 2026
    - 11th International Conference of the Evolutionary Demography Society, Colorado State University, June 2026

Oral Presentations

- **EJ Watson**, Delaney Glass, Lucia Petito. "Toward New Directions in Human Biology: A Roadmap for Causal Inference with Observational Data." Human Biology Association. Baltimore, MD. *2025*
- **EJ Watson.** "It's Biomedical Standard Time somewhere: Epigenetic clocks as a causal mechanism linking social and environmental exposures to health." *EpiCause 2024: Causality in Epidemiology* meeting at the Institute of Philosophy and Scientific Method. Johannes Kepler University of Linz, Austria. *2024*
- **EJ Watson,** TW McDade, CP Ryan, NR Lee, JL MacIsaac, K Dever, P Atashzay, MS Kobor, CW Kuzawa. "Evaluating the convergent and predictive validity of epigenetic age acceleration measured from common epigenetic clocks in Cebu, Philippines." Human Biology Association. Los Angeles, CA. (Awarded the E.E. Hunt, Jr. Student Award for Outstanding Podium Presentation). *2024*

Panels, Guest Lectures, and Workshops

- "Causal Inference with Observational Data," Guest lecture, University of Toronto, Department of Anthropology. *October 2025*.
- "Statistical versus causal inference." (Remote). Invited panelist for a round table discussion hosted by the Frontiers in Social Evolution (FINE) Seminar. *2022*
- "A primer on using directed acyclic graphs for causal inference." Workshop presentation for Northwestern's Evolutionary & Ecological Approaches to Health research group meeting. *2022*

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record, Northwestern University, Evanston, IL *2025*-Present

- **"Climate Change and Sustainability in Health Care" –** Winter 2025 & 2026
    - Co-designed NU's first medical school elective on climate and sustainability
    - Elective seminar for (10) first year medical students
    - Coordinated and facilitated seminars; lectured for 2 out of 5 sessions

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University Evanston, IL

- **"Intermediate Epidemiology"** | BIOSTAT 401 *2023*
  - Developed and gave lecture on Causal Inference with Directed Acyclic Graphs
- **"Introduction to Epidemiology"** | BIOSTAT 301 *2023*
- **"The Social Determinants of Health"** | Global Health 222 *2023*
- **"Introduction to Global Health"** | Public Health/Global Health 390 *2022*

Workshop Instructor, Northwestern University Evanston, IL

- **R for Social Data Science** *2024*
  - Designed and led a 5-session workshop (4–5 attendees weekly) on reproducible data science (R, tidyverse, RStudio, Quarto, GitHub).

Mentorship

Silas Colombara, Undergraduate Research Mentee *2023 – 2024*

- "Childhood Household Wealth Trajectories and Adult Mental Health in the Cebu Longitudinal Health and Nutrition Survey"

Other Research Experience

Field Researcher

- **UNC Center for Galápagos Studies & Galápagos Science Center** Isabela Island, Galapagos *2019*

Internships

- **Carolina Population Center**. UNC Chapel Hill *2018*
- **Scalabrini Centre of Cape Town, South Africa** *2017*
  - Refugee/Migrant Employment Access Programme Intern

Research Assistantships

- **UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health, Department of Epidemiology** *2018*

Op-eds

- "Opinion: Climate studies, National Institutes of Health Under Attack" Asheville Citizen Times *2025*

Service and Outreach

- **Northwestern Feinberg School of Medicine, Program in Public Health**
  - Curriculum Committee *2025 – Present*
- **Interdisciplinary Association for Population Health Science**
  - Student Committee, Webinar Co-Chair *2023 – 2025*

- **Boys & Girls Clubs of Chicago / Northwestern Science in Society Program**
    - Science Club Mentor, Pedersen-McCormick Boys & Girls Club *2023 – 2024*

Professional Society Memberships

Population Association of America; Interdisciplinary Association for Population Health Science; Human Biology Association; Evolutionary Demography Society

Additional Training

Workshops and Short Courses

- **Berkeley Workshop in Formal Demography,** University of California, Berkeley *2025*
- **Causal Inference with Time-Varying Exposures**, Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop *2023*
- **Introduction to Parametric and Semi-parametric Estimators for Causal Inference,** Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop *2023*
- **Writing Reproducible Research in R with Quarto,** Society for Epidemiologic Research workshop *2023*
- **Key Topics in Causal Inference,** CAUSALab, Department of Epidemiology, Harvard T. H. Chan School of Public Health *2022*
- **Mixtape Sessions: Causal Inference,** taught by Dr. Scott Cunningham *2022*